COVER STORY
PERSONALITY

A ROYAL AWAKENING

"My rebirth came from the goddess in 2019," says Radhikaraje Gaekwad, the titular maharani of the erstwhile state of Baroda, a textile revivalist and heritage conservationist. "It happened when we organised the garba at the Laxmivilas Palace in Vadodara for the first time. It was a high pressure event to organise and entailed charting completely new territory. Though I was a passionate dancer for many years, to host an event for 40,000 people was quite overwhelming," she recalls, sitting gracefully in an ornate chair, wearing a gorgeous Single Ikkat Rajkot Patola saree at the Laxmivilas Palace in Vadodara.

Coming from an unrestrained childhood, backing down in the face of a towering challenge was not her style. And so this became the 'turning point', she admits. "I looked inward, went deep to seek answers on what to do, how to mobilise resources, build and lead a team. Till then, I hadn't even realised that I had the vision for leadership. I found that confidence, stillness, ability to absorb stress, building a community, effective communication helped achieve the external goals—all through the feminine energy of the goddess," she says gently.

Although she confesses that she is not much of a ritualistic person, during Navratri puja, Gaekwad found an embracing energy elevating her, especially during those nine nights. "It was complete surrender; an inward spiritual journey that helped me find my voice—one that was benevolent, nurturing, cleansing, and definitely feminine. It was very personal and satisfying. And doing the garba in unison with 40,000 people, around the goddess, as an ode to feminine energy, I found my space; I found myself," she reflects.
As she awoke to her potential, she recognised her leadership skills and her ability to create a community of people; the power to motivate and organise them around an idea to work towards mutually meaningful goals. After that there was no looking back. "My endeavours entailed risks, which I willingly took to push the envelope." She decided to represent women and marginalised communities, effectively becoming a voice for the voiceless. "Trusting their judgement in their individual spaces. I opened the doors for the LGBTQI community and the HIV positive people to be part of our mainstream workforce. I found the strength for starting the *Naari ki Sawari* campaign—teaching women to drive; for the LGBTQI community to manage temples, perform the puja and organising the drag garba during Navratri. I found my purpose by becoming a voice for them," she admits.

As a heritage conservationist, Gaekwad works towards reviving the Chanderi and Baroda Shalu weave of sarees—traditional Indian sarees woven in Banaras, and an integral part of Maratha royal sartorial traditions. She assists the weavers with technical and design inputs, helps them contemporise their products, connects them with the end user and spreads awareness and consciousness about these weaves through social media; wearing them herself and talking about it on national and international platforms. Walking the talk is the Gaekwad way to extend royal patronage, bridging the past to a post modern future. In recognising and owning her inner brilliance and feminine energy, she has succeeded in inspiring and aiding scores to recognise and reflect their own iridescence.

—Jumana Shah

Jewellery: **Reborn: Solitaires by Zoya**